

To: Professor Klena

From: James Davis, Cyber Law 406, UIN #01270342

Subject: Freedom of Expression and Privacy in the Digital World

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1. Freedom of Expression. The platforms that I use to communicate information include Discord, Microsoft Teams, Microsoft Outlook, and Mozilla Thunderbird. While this section will focus on Discord, I also trust Microsoft Teams because of its use of Transport Layer Security (TLS) and Secure Real-Time Transport Protocol (SRTP). Additionally, Microsoft Outlook seamlessly integrates with the Duo Mobile app that Old Dominion University relies on as a 2FA solution. Lastly, I trust Mozilla Thunderbird because it does not collect or sell user data, and it also provides access to numerous settings across multiple email accounts (including security configurations). Discord is the platform I use the most because I have had multiple opportunities to chat with classmates, coworkers, and friends within small group channels, voice calls, and direct messages. I trust Discord because it facilitates end-to-end encryption for voice calls, and I can use it with Authy, a mobile app that can be used for 2FA. While text messages are not encrypted, I refrain from sharing sensitive information on Discord. According to Discord's Terms of Service (ToS) and its Community Guidelines, content is actively monitored by relying on both human moderation and automated detection systems. The policies forbid illegal content sharing, hate speech, and other threats. Furthermore, Discord encourages its users to report known violations of the ToS and Community Guidelines. While I have had some negative experiences in some public servers, the moderation policy remains effective because Discord provides multiple ways to report various issues; users may report specific messages, or they can choose to report a

user profile instead. Fortunately, I have very rarely had to report content or users, but this is also because I do not participate in large public servers; only small public and private servers where most members treat each other with mutual respect and do not engage in malicious activities.

2. Privacy and Personal Information. While I have had to share personal information with numerous entities cumulatively over the years, it is banks and other financial institutions that hold some of my most sensitive information. For example, I am required to share my full legal name, Social Security Number (SSN), date of birth, address, and employer information (to facilitate direct deposits) with my local bank that holds my savings and checking accounts. After reviewing the *Consumer Privacy Notice of Atlantic Union Bank*, this bank collects its customers' SSNs & income, account balances & transaction history, and payment & credit history. Furthermore, this bank's *Consumer Privacy Notice* provides a full breakdown of each reason personal information can or cannot be shared. For each potential reason, a separate Yes/No column is also provided, which answers whether the customer may limit a particular form of sharing. Unfortunately, I was interested to find out that this document does not detail how this bank protects personal information; instead, such details are outlined in the bank's *Business Online Banking User's Guide*, which has a section dedicated to account security that discloses the use of encryption, firewalls, intrusion detection, robust authentication, virus protection, and application security. This document goes into further detail about what its application security consists of. Also, users have the option to create & manage several types of alerts (including security alerts) and manage 2FA delivery methods. While this bank could consider improving how it provides privacy and security documentation, its policy adequately protects the personal information I share with them. However, I understand that it is important that all banks and other

financial institutions need to regularly assess their security controls and documentation as new threats (and technologies to combat such threats) emerge in the long-term. Likewise, while I appreciate *Atlantic Union Bank* for maintaining the *Security & Fraud Center* on its website, in addition to eye-catching banners on its website that highlight ongoing scams (which I've observed recently, unfortunately), prevention strategies and response protocols must also be regularly assessed to ensure they remain accurate and effective.

3. Online Presence Concerns. The largest concern I have about my online presence is the risk of a data breach occurring, especially if it results in my financial information being compromised. This especially concerns me as someone who remains constantly focused on saving and investing, because I wonder what personal information could be exposed on various platforms that I have used over the years. For example, a *Forbes* report titled *UnitedHealth Data Breach Escalates: 190 Million Americans Affected* discusses the Change Healthcare ransomware attack that occurred about a year ago, which is an incident that really concerns me due to the astonishing number of Americans that had either their personal information or healthcare information compromised. This includes its customers' SSNs, medical records, and billing information. To worsen the situation, UnitedHealth issued a \$22 million ransom payment, which was done to avoid having the threat actors leak data, and to hopefully decrypt the systems that were encrypted. This provides sufficient evidence that ransomware payments provide no protection guarantees (Vakulov, 2025). To give another example that pertains to my concerns about data breaches, a *Reuters* article titled *Rhode Island hit by data breach as hackers demand ransom* discusses the December 2024 incident involving Rhode Island's state portal for social services (also known as RIBridges). While I acknowledge that this is another example of a

ransomware attack, it continues to fascinate me how many times such incidents have occurred not only within businesses, but also government systems. For example, in this case, files containing personally identifiable information (PII) were stolen. Although the scope of this attack was smaller than that of the Change Healthcare ransomware attack (amounting to hundreds of thousands of victims compared to hundreds of millions), part of what fascinates me about the RIBridges attack is how it provides yet another example of healthcare information being exposed, in addition to other programs such as SNAP. It is especially sickening to me that there are threat actors who target not only large corporations, but also American government entities that manage the data necessary to support struggling citizens (McKay, 2024). Overall, both these incidents (among many other data breaches, ransomware attacks, etc.) demonstrate that sensitive information can still be exploited by threat actors even with the existence of various policies and forms of oversight. It concerns me that one of the inevitable realities of the ongoing information age is the vast network of numerous services that manage sensitive information. While I recognize that this is necessary to an extent (from a practical, functional standpoint), it does concern me that one weak link could put my identity or financial stance at risk. Over the past several years, all these concerns have prompted me to use a more sophisticated way to decrease digital security risk – by managing complex, unique passwords for every online service I use. Furthermore, I change these passwords on a regular basis, and I configure 2FA wherever possible to establish an additional security layer. Lastly, I remain cautious about the information I choose to share within online communication platforms, and I monitor online platforms (especially banks and other financial services) for known data breaches and other incidents to determine what can be done to prevent or mitigate such scenarios. Nonetheless, I accept the reality that no digital presence is perfectly safe forever, and that it will require

consistent, lifelong effort for everyone involved, including various types of organizations and each of their end users.